

out, his reaction was brilliant. 'Let's wear it as a badge on a shirt. And let's be fine. Let's keep the chin up'. He likes to keep good vibes in the room. I had a great time being with him.

And how was the experience with Rahul Dravid?

Rahul is the best coach I've worked with. He has a great character and is good at what he does. He talks well, is very thorough, and is disciplined with his coaching. He took over when India was in a transition phase with significant challenges ahead. We were good friends. And we are even better friends now. The expectations were higher when he joined. He was calm and composed through these challenging times.

What was this talk of India changing the pitch ahead of the 2023 ODI World Cup final in Ahmedabad?

I've heard this story that the pitch was different, which I don't agree with at all. We played on similar wickets in the earlier matches as well. Matches against Australia, Pakistan, England were also played on slow pitches. The Ahmedabad pitch, however, eased out.

What were your memorable moments from the T20 World Cup?

Suryakumar (Yadav) taking that catch in the final. Jasprit Bumrah won it for us, honestly. What he did as a bowler is beyond explanation; the level of control he demonstrated is unbelievable. We are incredibly fortunate to have Bumrah on our team. Also, Hardik (Pandya) came good when needed.

What is your biggest takeaway as a selector and coach — picking Jasprit Bumrah, winning the series in Australia, or winning the T20 World Cup?

Both. Australia will always be a very special series for us. We played different formats and faced challenging situations, especially after Virat's departure following the first Test. We had new players, initially net bowlers, stepping up to



Pillar of strength: Vikram Rathour says he owes much of his success to his wife, Deepali, who managed the household brilliantly, allowing him to focus on his work. **V. MOORTHY**

play Test cricket.

The open-bus ride in Mumbai [after the T20 World Cup win] was unforgettable; it was the first time I had seen such a huge turnout on Marine Drive. It was an incredible experience.

When identifying a player for big platforms, is it only about talent?

We put too much emphasis on talent, which is the skill to bat or bowl. Eventually, I learned that there are bigger things in cricket— your decision-making. Are you under pressure? What is your character when under pressure? How do you deal with adversity? So, those are the things that matter more than just having talent.

How about the IPL?

IPL has helped in a big way because that has given a lot of confidence to many players. You are competing with international players in a domestic tournament, which is

excellent.

When I played for the Indian team, the only guy who bowled 140+ kmph was maybe Javagal Srinath. I had played him only once. So, that was my exposure to fast bowling. Now, people are playing against the best fast bowlers in the IPL. So, their experience is entirely different. It's easier for them to handle that pressure.

A word on your family's contribution during your successful tenure.

I am deeply grateful to my family for their unwavering support. I owe a great deal of credit to my wife, Deepali, for enabling me to concentrate on my work. She managed the household brilliantly and raised our son and daughter with love and discipline. Despite my constant travels, my family has always stood by me. I am indebted to them as they are my most dedicated support team.